

Lieutenant Colonel James "Rhodey" Rhodes has a tough role to fill—not just as a high-level military officer, but as Tony Stark's best friend. Tony isn't known for following rules, and it's Rhodey's job to follow them closely. So Rhodey often must run interference for Iron Man, sometimes defending him to Congress or using his authority to clear Iron Man's flights with the military.

In Iron Man 2, Rhodey borrowed Tony's Mark II armor. He weaponized the suit and became War Machine, operating under the direction of the U.S. military.

By the time we see War Machine in Iron Man 3, he's gotten a Stark upgrade and is now, as Digital Sculptor Josh Herman of Marvel Studios' Visual Development Department says, "sleeker, more refined and athletic in the same way that Iron Man is."

There's still a world of difference between War Machine and Iron Man—you can tell at a glance which suit belongs to Rhodey, and not just by the silver color and the swiveling minigun. "War Machine is more angular and military," Herman explains. "He feels just a little more aggressive—with more plating, more layers, and fewer flowing lines. He's more square."

"Square" is probably not how Rhodey would describe anything he wears—though once he's rebranded as Iron Patriot and painted red, white, and blue, he might actually look the part.

And even with the new paint job, the suits are still—as Rhodey said the first time he got a look at one of Tony's armors—the coolest thing he's ever seen.



Art by Ryan Meinerding.